

Mengnan Xu

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PhD Candidate, Public Management, Beijing Normal University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Chinese politics and governance; state capacity and organizational mobilization; development governance; China's poverty alleviation programs; AI and computational methods for social science; political economy of China; South–South cooperation and international development.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Candidate, Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy</i>	<i>Oct 2018 – current</i> Beijing, China
Master of Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy</i>	<i>Sep 2016 – Jun 2018</i> Beijing, China
Master of Science, Information Technology and Management <i>University of Texas at Austin, McCombs School of Business</i>	<i>Jul 2023 – May 2024</i> Austin, TX, USA
Bachelor of Management Science and Engineering, Management Information Systems <i>Central South University</i>	<i>Sep 2008 – Jun 2012</i> Changsha, China

Doctoral Dissertation:

The Impact of Targeted Poverty Alleviation Policies on Long-Term Development and Vulnerability to Poverty Relapse Among Rural Households: Evidence from a Quasi-Natural Experiment Using CFPS Panel Data
Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy.
Passed blind external review; oral defense scheduled May 2026.

VISITING POSITIONS

Visiting Doctoral Researcher <i>Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin</i> <i>China Scholarship Council Fellowship</i>	<i>Aug 2021 – Aug 2022</i> Austin, TX, USA
Visiting Scholar <i>University of Oxford</i>	<i>Sep – Oct 2019</i> Oxford, UK

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

China Scholarship Council (CSC) Fellowship for Visiting Doctoral Research, Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin. Aug 2021–Aug 2022.

STEPS Summer School Scholarship, Institute of Development Studies (IDS), University of Sussex. 2021.

Young Scholars Forum Scholarship, University of Hong Kong. 2018.

PUBLICATIONS & WORKING PAPERS

Xu, Mengnan, Robert Walker, and Lichao Yang. “Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China.” *Journal of Contemporary China*, 31(136), 756–769, 2022. DOI: 10.1080/10670564.2021.2010878. (SSCI Q1; **First Author**)

Xu, Mengnan et al. “Tobacco Control Policy Evaluation in China: Evidence from Administrative Panel Data.” *BMJ Open*, 2019.

Xu, Mengnan et al. “[. The Impact of Tobacco Taxation Policy on Slim Cigarette Use and the Growing Popularity of Slim Cigarettes in China Since 2014].” *Health*, 2019.

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Organizational Ecology and Multi-Actor State Mobilization in China’s Poverty Alleviation Governance.” *Working paper, under revision*.

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Computational Methods for Large-Scale Chinese Policy Document Analysis: A Text-as-Data Approach to Governance Research.” *Working paper, in preparation*.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Technical Research Analyst

Gates Foundation–Funded Research Initiative, Beijing Normal University

Sep 2016 – May 2018

Beijing, China

- Led end-to-end coordination of multi-year research programs on development governance and public administration reform, aligning international funding requirements with academic deliverables.
- Designed and executed large-scale quantitative and qualitative data collection; performed statistical analysis using SAS, Stata, and Python to support policy recommendations.
- Built an original organizational ecology database tracking actors, resource flows, and governance logic across China’s national non-profit organization, drawing on yearbooks, government reports, and policy documents.
- Applied data ETL pipelines (topic modeling, named-entity recognition, keyword co-occurrence networks) to Chinese-language policy corpora exceeding 10,000 documents.
- Translated empirical findings into policy briefs and analytical reports for program leadership and external stakeholders.
- Managed annual planning, milestone tracking, and cross-institutional coordination across government, university, and foundation partners.

Graduate Research Assistant, Public Management

Beijing Normal University, School of Government

Sep 2016 – Jun 2018

Beijing, China

- Conducted literature reviews, archival research, and comparative policy analysis on Chinese governance, state-society relations, and public administration.
- Contributed to faculty research projects examining central–local government relations and organizational reform in China.

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer / AI Engineer

Apple Inc.

Jun 2025 – Mar 2026

Austin, TX, USA

- Developed components for Apple’s Intelligence platform, focusing on production-scale natural language processing pipelines and retrieval-augmented generation architectures.
- Applied large language model techniques to large-scale information processing and knowledge integration systems, gaining first-hand engineering experience with the tools now central to computational social science.

Software Engineer

Applied Optical Technologies

Apr 2026 – Present

Houston, TX, USA

- Built full-pipeline automated data monitoring and analytics system for manufacturing execution processes.
- Designed modules for large-scale data collection, cleaning, and multi-dimensional statistical analysis.

Senior Risk Analyst

Agricultural Bank of China

Jul 2012 – Jun 2016

Hengyang, China

- Extracted and analyzed large-scale financial datasets using SQL and statistical modeling to support risk management and policy analytics.
- Developed credit scoring models (logistic regression, WOE binning) that reduced default rates and improved loan processing efficiency.

METHODOLOGICAL AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

Quantitative and Computational Methods: Regression analysis, difference-in-differences, network analysis, causal inference; Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), R, SQL, STATA/SAS.

AI and NLP for Social Science: Large language models (fine-tuning, retrieval-augmented generation, prompt engineering), topic modeling (LDA, BERTopic), named-entity recognition, text classification, word embeddings; LangChain, OpenAI API, Hugging Face, AI agentic engineering.

Data Infrastructure: AWS (S3, Lambda, SageMaker), BigQuery, MySQL, MongoDB; Git, Jupyter, Tableau, Power BI.

Research Methods: Archival and documentary analysis, qualitative case study, elite interviews, survey research.

LANGUAGES

Mandarin Chinese Native

English Proficient (academic writing, presentations, and publication)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.